

became obsessed with proving to them that he was successful. One day, Bret figured out how he could at least get in the race, if not keep up with the Joneses. He applied for his first of many credit cards from an application at the bookstore.

He used this newfound source of money to pay for expensive clothes, designer eyeglasses, and fine dining. These acquisitions came with such ease that he even traded in his used car for a new one financed with a hefty loan. Kim wondered where Bret was getting the money to pay for all these things and he explained that his scholarship money included a very generous living allowance.

This charade worked for a while. He even started to feel comfortable around Kim's parents. One day, Bret received his first of many collector phone calls at his dorm and he knew that the game was over. His debt far exceeded the small living allowance (not the generous one he told Kim) he received from his scholarship. Bret decided to get a part-time job. This helped initially, but unfortunately Bret continued to spend. He had gotten used to living a more privileged lifestyle and he strongly resisted going back.

When he realized he had to work full-time in order to pay his bills, he made the decision to quit school temporarily. When Bret finally confessed his debt to Kim, she was at first confused and then furious. How could Bret drop out of school? What about their high hopes for their future together? Kim couldn't understand the driving force behind Bret's spending. She had never felt the inadequacy that Bret did around people with money. To her it didn't matter whether Bret had money or not. She was completely baffled by his actions and, feeling betrayed, decided to call off the engagement.

If Bret had been honest with Kim about his feelings of inadequacy around her family, maybe Kim could have assured him that it didn't matter to her how much money he had. This

